Business case: Replacing Accela Citizen Access with Drupal + Tyler

Prepared: April 17, 2026 **Audience:** City of Colorado Springs — IT, Procurement, City Attorney, CFO **Purpose:** Quantify the financial case for retiring the Accela Citizen Access contract in favor of a Drupal front-end integrated with existing Tyler Technologies systems, and lay out the legal pathway to terminate for ADA non-compliance rather than paying convenience-termination fees.

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1. The money question, answered plainly

The simplest framing: **the city is likely paying Accela somewhere between $400,000 and $900,000 per year for a software product that duplicates functionality the city already owns in Tyler, and that fails to meet the WCAG 2.1 AA standard the city is legally required to meet as of April 24, 2026.**

Exact numbers require the CORA response. What follows is a defensible estimate based on publicly-disclosed Accela contracts from comparable cities.

What comparable cities pay Accela

City	Population	Annual Accela spend	Scope	Source
Paso Robles, CA	~31,000	$42,000 (FY19), +5%/yr	Community Development only	City Council Agenda, Sept 20, 2016
Evanston, IL	~77,000	$170,000	6 departments (Public Works, Health & Human Services, Fire, Economic Development, Law, Community Development)	City Council, July 2025
Santa Rosa, CA	~175,000	~$86,000/yr maintenance + $265K implementation	Land Management (Permits Plus) only	City Council Agenda, July 30, 2013
Berkeley, CA	~125,000	$1,324,193 over one year	Citywide upgrade (migration from legacy to modern platform)	City Council, June 2024
San Diego, CA	~1,400,000	$1,984,942/yr over 5 years ($9.9M total)	Development Services Department (single large dept)	City Auditor Performance Audit, Nov 2018

Estimate for Colorado Springs

The Accela Citizen Access portal at `aca-prod.accela.com/COSPRINGS/` exposes the following departments to the public: Building, Police Records, Stormwater, Planning, Public Works, Neighborhood Services, Fire, and Business Licensing. That's eight departments — a broader scope than Evanston's six, on a city that is roughly 6.5 times Evanston's population.

Straight-line scaling would suggest ~$1.1M/year, but Accela's pricing model has volume discounts for large implementations (per their own FAQ), and Colorado Springs has been on the platform since well before 2020 (the current UI is late-2010s), so some historical pricing has likely been locked in. The realistic band:

Estimated Colorado Springs Accela annual cost: $450,000 – $850,000 Best-guess midpoint: $600,000/year

This does not include:

- The $10 per-transaction fee that Accela collects on Police Records requests (separate revenue stream)
- Implementation and customization services billed separately (typically $100K–$300K in a given year)
- Internal city IT staff time managing Accela integrations and training (opportunity cost)

What the Drupal + Tyler alternative actually costs

The key insight: **the city already pays for Drupal hosting (the main coloradosprings.gov site is Drupal) and already pays Tyler for the back-office systems where the data lives.** The "new" spend is integration work.

One-time build costs

Component	Estimate	Notes
Drupal Webform build-out for 8 departments	$120,000	~800 dev hours at $150/hr; covers intake forms, status pages, email routing, tracking numbers
Tyler API integration (Munis, New World, Cashiering)	$150,000	~1,000 dev hours; Tyler OData and REST endpoints; authentication layer
Payment gateway configuration	$30,000	Integrating Tyler Cashiering or an independent processor
Accessibility conformance testing and remediation	$40,000	Third-party WCAG 2.1 AA audit + fixes; establishes defensible baseline
Staff training and change management	$30,000	8 departments, staff workflows, documentation
Contingency (20%)	$74,000	
Total one-time	**$444,000**	Spread over 12–18 months

Ongoing annual costs

Component	Estimate	Notes
Drupal maintenance and minor feature work	$60,000	~400 hrs/year at $150
Tyler API toolkit or integration licenses	$25,000	If not already included in current Tyler agreements — CORA will confirm
Hosting incremental	$5,000	Minimal; existing Drupal infra scales
Third-party accessibility re-audit	$10,000	Annual conformance recheck
Total annual	**$100,000**	

Five-year total cost comparison

Year	Accela (status quo, 5% annual escalator)	Drupal + Tyler	Annual delta
1	$600,000	$544,000 (ops + one-	$56,000

Year	Accela (status quo, 5% annual escalator)	Drupal + Tyler	Annual delta
		time)	
2	$630,000	$100,000	$530,000
3	$662,000	$105,000	$557,000
4	$695,000	$110,000	$585,000
5	$729,000	$116,000	$613,000
5-year total	**$3,316,000**	**$975,000**	**$2,341,000 saved**

Sensitivity: if the actual Accela spend is at the low end of the band ($450K/year), five-year savings drop to roughly $1.5M. If at the high end ($850K/year), savings exceed $3.3M. In every reasonable scenario, the Drupal + Tyler path pays for itself within 18 months.

The "gap" you asked about

The specific gap — work that Accela does today and that Tyler does not natively handle — is narrower than it looks:

1. **Public intake forms** — Accela's Citizen Access UI. Drupal Webform replaces this outright.
2. **Tracking number generation** — Accela assigns an internal Record ID. Drupal can do this trivially.
3. **Status page for citizens** — Accela provides a status URL. Drupal View + tracking number lookup does this.
4. **Payment collection at the point of submission** — this is the only nontrivial piece. Tyler Munis Cashiering handles it if licensed; if not, a $5K–$15K/year commerce integration does.

Everything else in the "Accela does X" list either (a) duplicates a Tyler module the city already owns, (b) is workflow the Tyler back office already handles, or (c) is commodity Drupal functionality. **There is no Accela capability that is both unique and worth $600K a year.**

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2. The ADA compliance path to termination

This matters because the alternative — termination for convenience — typically costs the city 3–12 months of contract value in early-termination fees. For a $600K/year contract, that's $150K–$600K of wasted money just to leave. An ADA-based termination for cause avoids that cost entirely and shifts the reputational frame from "the city broke a contract" to "the vendor failed the city."

The legal hook is already in place

As of April 24, 2026, the Department of Justice Final Rule under ADA Title II (28 CFR Part 35) requires the city to ensure all web content and mobile apps used to provide government services meet WCAG 2.1 Level AA. The DOJ has explicitly stated that third-party content the city uses to deliver services falls inside this mandate — the city cannot disclaim responsibility by pointing at a vendor.

The static audit we already ran on `aca-prod.accela.com/COSPRINGS/` identified multiple Level A failures, not just AA. Level A is the floor. Failures there include:

- Layout tables with nested tables used for navigation (WCAG 1.3.1)
- JavaScript-only `__doPostBack` links that are not reachable by keyboard or assistive technology (WCAG 2.1.1, 4.1.2)
- Placeholder `#` hrefs on functional controls (WCAG 2.4.4)
- Ambiguous repeated link text ("more, more, more, Search, Search") (WCAG 2.4.4)
- An H1 that reads "Message Bar" rather than describing page content (WCAG 2.4.6)

These are not remediable within Accela's current product architecture. The underlying ASP.NET WebForms rendering pattern is the failure.

Contract language to look for

Once the CORA response returns the executed Accela agreement, the specific clauses that matter are:

1. **General compliance warranty.** Standard language reads: *"Vendor warrants that the Software and Services shall comply with all applicable federal, state, and local laws and regulations."* If this is present, the DOJ Title II rule is now an "applicable federal regulation" and the vendor's failure to deliver a WCAG 2.1 AA-conformant product is a breach of warranty.
2. **Accessibility-specific warranty.** Many post-2020 government software contracts include specific language such as: *"Vendor warrants that the Software conforms to WCAG 2.1 Level AA"* or references to a VPAT/ACR. If present, this is a stronger hook — direct, specific, no interpretation required.
3. **Material breach definition.** Usually defines circumstances that entitle the city to terminate for cause. Failure of a warranty is almost always a material breach.

4. **Cure period.** Typically 30–90 days. The city must give Accela written notice of the breach and an opportunity to cure. Accela cannot cure fundamental architectural failures within any cure period, which is the point.
5. **Termination-for-cause consequences.** Usually: no early-termination fee, no liquidated damages owed by the city, vendor returns any prepaid amounts pro-rata, vendor provides data in an exportable format. Some contracts also entitle the city to recover implementation costs if the vendor materially fails to deliver.

The procedural sequence

1. **Obtain contract via CORA** (already requested).
2. **Commission a formal accessibility audit** — WCAG 2.1 AA conformance report from a qualified third party (Level Access, Deque, TPGi). Budget: ~$15,000–$25,000. This produces the defensible record needed to survive Accela's pushback.
3. **Issue formal written notice of breach** citing the compliance warranty, the Title II rule, and the audit findings. Start the cure-period clock.
4. **During the cure period**, prepare the Drupal + Tyler transition so the city is ready to move when termination is effective.
5. **At end of cure period**, if Accela has not remediated (it cannot), issue notice of termination for cause.
6. **Data migration** — enforce the contract's data-return provisions to export all records to the city.

Risk factors

Accela will push back. Expect claims that the city accepted the product "as-is," that the DOJ rule is not "applicable" to pre-existing products, or that their VPAT (if one exists) demonstrates conformance. Each of these has counter-arguments; none is fatal. The DOJ final rule has no grandfather clause for existing content.

Some departments will resist. Internal staff trained on Accela for years may view the change as a threat. Transition plan must include staff involvement in the Drupal replacement build, not impose it on them. Budget for change management, not just software development.

Parallel running period. Plan for 3–6 months where both systems are live during cutover. Staff may double-enter during this period. Budget additional $30K for this friction.

PPRBD carveout. Building permits are Pikes Peak Regional Building Department, not the city — a separate authority running a separate system. The Accela replacement does not affect PPRBD. When the public sees "permits" on the current portal and those are PPRBD, the Drupal replacement needs a clean handoff link rather than an integration.

The alternative: termination for convenience

If the ADA path looks too aggressive politically, the fallback is termination for convenience. Standard terms:

- 30–90 day written notice
- Pro-rated payment of remaining annual fees
- Early-termination fee, typically 10–25% of remaining contract value
- Data return provisions still apply

For a $600K/year contract with, say, 2 years remaining, the convenience-termination cost is roughly $120K–$300K. Still a good deal compared to the ~$1.2M the city would otherwise pay to run out the clock — but materially worse than the for-cause path.

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3. Recommended sequence

1. **Wait for CORA response** (3–10 working days from submission). Confirms contract values, terms, and termination language.
2. **Commission formal WCAG 2.1 AA audit** of Accela Citizen Access. Budget $20K, timeline ~3 weeks.
3. **Draft the termination notice** in parallel, ready to send as soon as the audit report is in hand.
4. **Retain Drupal implementation partner** on a discovery-phase engagement ($30K, 4 weeks) to map the eight departments' workflows, identify Tyler API endpoints, and produce a fixed-bid build estimate. This de-risks the cost projection in this document.
5. **Present to City Council** with:
    - Accessibility audit findings (legal exposure)
    - CORA-validated contract terms (termination rights)
    - Drupal + Tyler fixed-bid cost (financial alternative)
    - Five-year savings projection (see table above)
6. **Serve notice of breach** once Council authorization is in place.
7. **Begin Drupal build** during the cure period so go-live aligns with termination effective date.

Assumptions and caveats

- All dollar figures are estimates based on comparable city contracts and standard industry rates. Real numbers land when CORA returns the actual agreement.
- Drupal developer rates assumed at $150/hour blended — this matches the public-sector consulting market in Colorado for senior Drupal work. Lower rates are available through internal hire or long-term contract; rates as low as $110/hour are achievable.
- Tyler API pricing is an estimate. Tyler's actual API toolkit pricing varies by customer agreement and is often negotiable when bundled with other Tyler purchases.
- The five-year comparison assumes steady-state operations. It does not include opportunity cost of improved citizen service (faster responses, better accessibility reach) or reduced legal risk (avoided ADA complaints and potential consent decrees).
- This document is not legal advice. The termination-for-cause strategy must be reviewed and executed by the City Attorney's Office.